

Automation Ahoy!

I TOOK A RIDE ON A DRIVERLESS BUS THIS MONTH. The RAC Intellibus is a trial project being run in Perth, Australia, using which they hope to learn more about how people behave on roads, and to hone the skills of the “Intellibus”. That’s in quotes because the bus is far from what I would call “intelligent”. Essentially it’s been programmed to run a very tightly controlled loop, and has paranoid levels of safety. Travelling at about 14 kmph, the bus felt too slow, and when cyclists overtook it, the 3D LIDAR would sense them and jam brakes in a way that is certainly not coffee friendly... which is why you’re not allowed hot drinks on the bus. Although it seemed to be more programmed rather than AI, it was still interesting to see the bus react in real time, without any inputs from the nice lady holding the Xbox controller that can be used for emergencies – she’s never used it. I asked.

It really got me thinking about how close we really are to total automation! And then another form of automation caught my attention this month. When I learnt that Google was launching a Home Hub (basically a Google Home with a 7-inch screen), I decided to buy one. Why? Because I have a Google Home, and I have rudimentary levels of automation in my rented house, but being me, I’m obviously going to want more...

When I finally own my own place, I plan to automate the heck out of it. I want to dive headlong into the whole smart home phenomenon that’s starting to sweep across western countries. From cameras to phones and home security systems to my AC, and even the lights, locks on the front doors, everything! Why? Because I’m a tech-head, and if I *can* do something with tech, then I *must* do it.

The Google Home Hub is a step in the right direction. These audio-only assistant devices were beginning to irritate me. Since I always have my smartphone with me, I found that there were very rare instances where I would use my Google Home for anything except playing some music while I relax. Sure, I would ask it to tell me what the weather would be like tomorrow, or ask it to save something in my calendar, but then I realised I would end up looking at the device, looking to see the visual

indicator that it had heard me when I said “Hey Google”, and I wasn’t just talking to the walls like an idiot...

It’s not just for visual cues that I like the Home Hub, it’s because we are so programmed to search for screens now that if you don’t have one, it almost seems incomplete. Add to that the fact that almost all online “news” these days is in video format, and it’s obvious that to keep abreast with the events of the world you need a screen. Yes I could have it play stuff on my smart TV, but that comes with another set of complications...

With the Google Home, all you ever do is use YouTube Music, or some other music service, whereas with the Home Hub, you can watch YouTube videos of stuff you are actually doing. For instance, I was sitting at my table trying to take apart a gadget, and despite having both hands occupied, I was able to ask Google to show me a video for how to open it – those hidden clips can be tricky!

Because I’m learning how to cook, I often look for recipes online. I’m ashamed to admit I have to use a recipe to even make an omelette (but only because I want it done restaurant quality). With just Google Assistant’s voice, I often found it impossible to understand what was happening – cooking involves a lot of visual skills. With the Home Hub, I can watch the recipe video as I cook. (I use the term “cook” very liberally here).

Now I’m sure that there are a few scenarios where a voice-only assistant device makes sense. I can’t think of any for me though. This is because I don’t have to look at the screen on the Home Hub, so everything Home can do, Hub can do as well, and much, much more. Now if only they’d put better speakers into the Hub...

I think these screen-less assistant devices for automation are already extinct. Anyone want to buy a rarely-used, (and pretty useless) Google Home? 



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